Azfar Moin writes, ‘to embody and perform their faith for [Akbar’s] pleasure’ – and a Fire Test would fit perfectly in the performative and participative – not to mention deadly – atmosphere of Akbar’s court, with the added advantage of ridding the emperor of yet another inconvenient shaikh, of course.

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The early 1580s were a do-or-die moment not only for Akbar’s warlords, but also for his clergy. Sometime in the first half of 1580, as the Bengal revolt gathered pace, Akbar’s qazi in Jaunpur issued a fatwa ‘insisting on the duty of taking the field and rebelling against the Emperor’.[19] Oddly enough, this qazi, Maulana Muhammad Yazd, was one of Akbar’s favoured interlocuters: not too long before he was posted to Jaunpur, the maulana was being pulled up to the emperor’s bedroom balcony for theological chats. Evidently, relations between the emperor and the scholar had grown sour. Badauni suggests the resentment may have been financial: Akbar was reassessing land grants to religious individuals and organizations just as he was reassessing his empire’s agricultural revenue.

Akbar took the maulana’s fatwa as seriously as he took the eastern insurrection. In June 1580, at the same time that Akbar sent Aziz, Todar Mal and Shahbaz Khan to Bihar and Bengal, the emperor sent another contingent of soldiers to Jaunpur, with orders to arrest the qazi. Abul Fazl is discreet about the affair, only accusing the maulana of ‘foolish talk and . . . strife-mongering’, because of which Akbar ordered him brought to court. As fate would have it, his boat ‘sank in the waves’ of the river en route. Badauni, however, declares that the drowning of Muhammad Yazd was no accident. Akbar, he writes, had ordered that the maulana be ‘made away with’.

The qazi of Jaunpur was not the only Muslim scholar or priest who lost his life or his position during this time: Akbar charged through their ranks as he had once galloped through the deep waters of the Ravi in Lahore.

‘[O]ne by one,’ writes Badauni, ‘he sent all the Mullas, against whom he had any suspicions of dissatisfaction, to the closet of annihilation.’ Mir Muizzulmulk, who, too, had been talking foolishly in Jaunpur, drowned with Muhammad Yazd; the qazi of Bengal followed soon after. Others,